



Sumod Hajela

The 1000 MB capacity captures your attention, but in truth the huge storage is only the foundation for Gmail. When Rediff offers 1024 MB free, and Yahoo!, Hotmail, etc. chip in with their few hundred MB sops, it is not the same—they still have a folder hierarchy based interface that will not scale. Google throws away the folders in favour of Labels. You can ‘apply’ several labels to a mail, as opposed to ‘putting’ the mail into one folder. Once you get used to labels, folders will feel decidedly primitive. The concept and the technology have been languishing for decades, but Google is the first to implement it on a scale that makes a difference. Score one for Google.

The Gmail interface is one huge JavaScript file, weighing in at around 250 KB. Sign-in and wait while this downloads. But once it is on your computer, the interface is simply blazing. The JavaScript processes all your clicks right on your computer, instead of relying on the server to decide what to do next. The only data needed from the server is your e-mail contents. Contrast this with almost all other Web-mail applications that force a full page reload on every click. Yahoo! recently bought Oddpost, the guys who first made this concept work for e-mail way back

Even in using it as just another Web-mail service, you will find the Gmail bookmarklets <http://snipurl.com/7ryw> handy. GmailTo will simply pop-up a Gmail compose window. GmailIt goes a step further—it will set the subject line to the title of the open Web page and put its URL in the body. The tiny GTray utility <http://snipurl.com/7ryt> will sit in your system tray and keep track of new mails in your Gmail account, like any e-mail notifier.

If you like Gmail enough to switch to it as your primary Web-mail provider, you may want to migrate mail from your existing Web-mail accounts to Gmail. One neat way to do this is to chain a tool such as the free Yahoo! POPs <http://snipurl.com/7ryp> with a mail redirection/forwarding tool like the free Mail Redirect <http://snipurl.com/7rys>. Mail Redirect will download mails from your Yahoo! account through YahooPOPs and transfer them to your Gmail account. Migrating from Hotmail is even easier with the free GetMail for Hotmail <http://snipurl.com/7ryn>, which does this in just one step!

You can turn your Gmail account into a standard POP3 account and download mail from it using a regular desktop email client with tools

Google Gets the Geeks Going

Let alone leading the race for the 1000 MB storage space, Google has been enterprising in replacing folders in the mail box with ‘labels’

in 2000. This interesting approach does have its accessibility drawbacks though, and Mark Pilgrim does a great job of presenting

them at <http://snipurl.com/7ryx>. These kinks, too, will eventually be sorted out, and you can safely credit Google with bringing yet another useful technology to front and centre. Welcome to the next wave of browser-based application interfaces.

Put a fast text-only interface, together with a flexible cutting edge organisation model, bring to it Google’s history of hackery and top it off with “Invite Only” exclusivity and you have the perfect recipe for a Geek popularity contest. Enough has been said about the ridiculous extents to which profiteers took this opportunity. Now that Google invites are worth about as much as two free Yahoo! accounts, that side-show is finally winding down.

Meanwhile, the geeks who did get these accounts early on have been busy making them more useful. Soon after Gmail launched, there was an explosion of utilities, many for things you could already do with existing Web-mail services and some unique to Gmail. Mark Lyons, an independent programmer, says “As an e-mail packrat, I jumped at the opportunity to have all my e-mail easily searchable. I decided to import my old e-mail from Netscape Communicator 4.7 (which had messages in it dating back to 1994). There was no upload feature included with Gmail, however. So I wrote one.”

such as ‘Pop Goes the Gmail’ <http://snipurl.com/7ryj> or FreePOPs <http://snipurl.com/7ryl> with the Gmail plug-in. Of course, that will completely negate the advantage of the new e-mail interface. Depending on your situation, moving your mail from your local mail client to Gmail might be a better idea. Mark Lyons’ Gmail Loader <http://snipurl.com/7rx2> is probably the best tool around for this. While it directly supports Mozilla/Thunderbird, Eudora and many Unix mail clients, Mark shows workarounds for others such as Outlook.

Filling up a 1000 MB mailbox would usually take some time, but Aaron Pratt filled his up in about a month. He used his Gmail account to run a public experiment <http://snipurl.com/7rxh> to test Gmail’s spam filter. If you are in a hurry to fill up your 1000 MB with something more useful than spam, you could try the Gmail backup script <http://snipurl.com/7rxt>. You can use it to save files to Gmail and download them if the need ever arises.

Put these tools to work and your Gmail account becomes much more useful than what you got when you signed up, and they work with standard Internet protocols and open-source contributions—in keeping with the honest hacker ethic.

But there is a little catch. You can’t legally use most of these tools. The Gmail Terms of Use states in Clause 5: “You also agree that you will not use any robot, spider, other automated device, or manual process to monitor or copy any content from the Service.”

Google is just another big corporation, after all. ■

Sumod Hajela, Associate Editor (Technology) is Digit’s Alpha Geek. His pastimes include creating new software during lunch hours, and mastering just about every computer-related technology that there is. Write to him at sumod_hajela@thinkdigit.com